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Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1986-1989

Coverage Date: 1895-1989

Place Coverage: KwaZulu Natal, South Africa

Section Title(S)

CONCLUSION • SOCIAL INTERACTION: THE CONTEXT FOR THE CLASH OF SUBCULTURES

Women, sensing rather than fully understanding the centrality of migrant labour as the mechanism which entrenches their inferior status, are deeply resentful of the bombast and self confidence returning migrants display. There is a definite sense in which women close ranks in solidarity against migrant men and attempt to restore them to lowered status by what has become a new form of a secular ritualised joking relationship. They also recognise very clearly their own dependence on the men's migrant earnings, which partly explains why it is the older women, many of whom are widows or divorcees (the former often being pensioners, with independent incomes), who are the main perpetrators of this joking relationship, while younger women tend to be willing and amused witnesses.

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CONCLUSION

A contention of this article is that a chasm exists between the interests of men and women who live at Kosi Bay. Some of these reflect tensions in gender relations in any society. In this case they are exacerbated by the strains exerted on relationships by the wrenching experience of migrant labour. Placed alongside this is a conundrum: why do the men of the area espouse a 'Zulu' identity, while most women cling to a 'Thonga' one? In a number of interviews, men have described themselves as Zulu and their sisters as Thonga.

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This apparent impossibility, where a brother and sister can have different ethnicities, is all too real, as we witness the struggle between the gender

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subcultures. It is important to understand the nature of these subcultures. The men and women of Kosi Bay are not invoking some primordial Zulu or Thonga culture, although they may sometimes couch their arguments in that vein. The versions of custom and tradition called upon to legitimise a particular action or point of view, are very locally specific, and may well be quite unrecognisable to an orthodox Zulu or Thonga person. Nevertheless, in this context, they pass for the real thing and, in some cases, do indeed appear to have an historical validity as well. It is as if the two genders are using idealised models reminiscent of the *gumsa* and *gumlao* constructs of Kachin society (Leach 1954:8–9).

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